

Acme Corp - Code of Conduct

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Approved By: Sarah Chen, VP of Human Resources & James Mitchell, CEO

Applies To: All Acme Corp employees, contractors, interns, and temporary workers

1. Purpose

This Code of Conduct establishes the ethical standards and behavioral expectations for everyone who represents Acme Corp. Our reputation depends on the integrity, professionalism, and ethical behavior of every team member.

2. Core Values

Acme Corp is guided by the following core values:

1. Integrity: We act honestly and transparently in all business dealings.
2. Respect: We treat every individual with dignity and consideration.
3. Excellence: We hold ourselves to the highest standards of quality in our work.
4. Collaboration: We believe in the power of teamwork and diverse perspectives.
5. Innovation: We encourage creative thinking and continuous improvement.
6. Accountability: We take ownership of our actions and their outcomes.

3. Professional Conduct

3.1 General Expectations

All employees are expected to:

- Perform their duties with competence, diligence, and integrity
- Treat colleagues, clients, partners, and vendors with respect and courtesy
- Maintain a professional appearance and demeanor appropriate to their role and work environment
- Be punctual and reliable in meeting commitments and deadlines

- Communicate openly, honestly, and constructively

3.2 Workplace Behavior

The following behaviors are prohibited at Acme Corp:

- Insubordination or refusal to follow reasonable management directives
- Disruptive behavior that interferes with the work of others
- Use of profane, abusive, or threatening language
- Unauthorized disclosure of confidential business information
- Falsification of company records, time sheets, expense reports, or other documents
- Sleeping during work hours (except during designated rest periods for night shift employees)
- Unauthorized possession or use of company property for personal purposes

4. Equal Employment Opportunity

Acme Corp is an equal opportunity employer and is committed to creating a diverse and inclusive workplace. We do not discriminate on the basis of:

- Race, color, or ethnicity
- Religion or creed
- National origin or ancestry
- Sex, gender, gender identity, or gender expression
- Sexual orientation
- Age (40 and over)
- Disability (physical or mental)
- Genetic information
- Veteran or military status
- Marital or familial status
- Pregnancy or related conditions
- Political affiliation
- Any other characteristic protected by applicable federal, state, or local law

5. Harassment and Discrimination

5.1 Zero-Tolerance Policy

Acme Corp has a zero-tolerance policy for harassment and discrimination of any kind. This applies to all

work-related settings, including:

- Acme Corp offices and facilities
- Remote work environments (e.g., video calls, chat platforms)
- Company-sponsored events, conferences, and social gatherings
- Business travel
- Online interactions in company communication channels

5.2 Definition of Harassment

Harassment includes but is not limited to:

- Verbal harassment: Slurs, epithets, derogatory jokes, offensive comments about a person's identity, unwelcome sexual comments or advances
- Physical harassment: Unwanted touching, blocking movement, physical intimidation, assault
- Visual harassment: Displaying offensive images, posters, or objects; sending offensive emails or messages
- Cyber harassment: Using digital channels to demean, threaten, or intimidate others
- Sexual harassment: Unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, or other verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature, particularly when:
 - Submission is made a condition of employment
 - Submission or rejection is used as the basis for employment decisions
 - The conduct unreasonably interferes with work performance or creates a hostile work environment

5.3 Reporting Harassment

Employees who experience or witness harassment should report it immediately to any of the following:

- Their direct manager (unless the manager is the subject of the complaint)
- The VP of Human Resources: sarah.chen@acmecorp.com
- The anonymous Ethics Hotline: (555) 246-8100 or ethics.acmecorp.com

All reports will be investigated promptly, thoroughly, and as confidentially as possible. Retaliation against anyone who reports harassment or participates in an investigation is strictly prohibited and will itself result in disciplinary action.

6. Conflicts of Interest

6.1 Definition

A conflict of interest arises when an employee's personal interests, relationships, or activities could interfere with - or appear to interfere with - their duties to Acme Corp.

6.2 Examples of Conflicts

- Having a financial interest in a competitor, supplier, or customer of Acme Corp
- Employment or consulting with a competitor while employed at Acme Corp
- Hiring or supervising a family member or close personal friend without disclosure
- Accepting gifts or entertainment from vendors or clients that could influence business decisions
- Using company resources, confidential information, or business opportunities for personal gain

6.3 Disclosure and Resolution

Employees must promptly disclose any actual or potential conflict of interest to their manager and the VP of Human Resources. The company will work with the employee to determine an appropriate resolution, which may include:

- Recusal from certain decisions or projects
- Divestiture of financial interests
- Modification of reporting relationships
- Other actions as appropriate

Failure to disclose a conflict of interest is itself a violation of this Code of Conduct.

7. Gifts and Entertainment

7.1 Receiving Gifts

Employees may accept nominal gifts (valued at \$50 or less) from clients, vendors, or partners. Gifts exceeding \$50 in value must be reported to the employee's manager and may need to be returned or donated.

The following types of gifts may never be accepted:

- Cash or cash equivalents (gift cards, cryptocurrency)
- Gifts that could create an obligation or influence business decisions
- Gifts from entities in an active bidding process with Acme Corp

7.2 Giving Gifts

Corporate gifts to clients, partners, or government officials must be pre-approved by the Legal department. Gifts to government officials are subject to strict legal limitations.

8. Confidentiality and Intellectual Property

8.1 Confidential Information

Employees have access to confidential information as part of their roles. This information must be:

- Used only for legitimate business purposes
- Shared only with authorized individuals on a need-to-know basis
- Protected from unauthorized disclosure during and after employment

Confidential information includes but is not limited to: business plans, financial data, customer lists, product roadmaps, source code, marketing strategies, personnel records, and any information marked "Confidential" or "Restricted."

8.2 Intellectual Property

All work product created by employees within the scope of their employment belongs to Acme Corp. This includes inventions, software code, designs, documentation, processes, and other creative works.

Employees must sign an Intellectual Property Assignment Agreement as a condition of employment.

8.3 Post-Employment Obligations

Confidentiality obligations survive the termination of employment. Former employees must:

- Return all company property, documents, and data upon separation
- Not use or disclose confidential information after leaving Acme Corp
- Comply with any non-compete or non-solicitation agreements signed during employment

9. Use of Company Resources

9.1 Acceptable Use

Company resources (computers, phones, internet, email, office supplies, vehicles, facilities) are provided for business use. Limited, reasonable personal use is permitted provided it:

- Does not interfere with job performance
- Does not violate any other company policy
- Does not involve illegal, offensive, or inappropriate content

9.2 Prohibited Use

Company resources must never be used for:

- Personal business ventures or side employment
- Political campaigning or fundraising
- Religious proselytizing
- Viewing, downloading, or distributing offensive or illegal content
- Unauthorized copying or distribution of copyrighted material
- Activities that violate the Information Security Policy (ACME-IT-001) or Acceptable Use Policy (ACME-IT-002)

10. Substance Abuse

10.1 Drug-Free Workplace

Acme Corp maintains a drug-free workplace. The following are prohibited:

- Reporting to work under the influence of illegal drugs or alcohol
- Using, possessing, distributing, or manufacturing illegal drugs on company premises or during work hours
- Misusing prescription medications in a way that impairs job performance

10.2 Alcohol at Company Events

Alcohol may be served at company-sponsored events. Employees are expected to consume responsibly and ensure they have safe transportation home.

10.3 Support and Assistance

Employees struggling with substance abuse are encouraged to seek help through the Acme Corp Employee Assistance Program (EAP), which provides confidential counseling and referral services at no cost. Contact the EAP at (555) 321-7890 or eap@acmecorp.com.

11. Social Media and Public Communications

11.1 Personal Social Media

Employees are free to use personal social media. However, when your affiliation with Acme Corp is apparent, you

must:

- Clearly state that your views are personal and not those of Acme Corp
- Not disclose confidential company information
- Not make statements that could be construed as official Acme Corp positions
- Treat colleagues, competitors, and partners respectfully

11.2 Official Company Accounts

Only authorized employees (typically in Marketing and Communications) may post on behalf of Acme Corp on official social media accounts. All official communications must be reviewed and approved by the Communications team.

12. Reporting Violations and Whistleblower Protection

12.1 Duty to Report

All employees have a duty to report known or suspected violations of this Code of Conduct, company policies, or applicable laws. Reports can be made to:

- Your direct manager
- The VP of Human Resources
- The anonymous Ethics Hotline: (555) 246-8100 or ethics.acmecorp.com

12.2 Non-Retaliation

Acme Corp strictly prohibits retaliation against any employee who in good faith:

- Reports a violation or suspected violation
- Participates in an investigation
- Refuses to participate in activity that would violate this Code

Anyone who retaliates against a reporting employee will be subject to disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

12.3 Investigation Process

1. All reports are acknowledged within 2 business days.
2. An investigation is initiated within 5 business days.
3. The investigation is conducted by HR and/or an independent investigator as appropriate.
4. Findings and recommended actions are communicated to relevant parties within 30 business days of the

report.

5. All investigation records are maintained securely for a minimum of 7 years.

13. Disciplinary Action

Violations of this Code of Conduct may result in disciplinary action, which may include:

- Verbal or written warning
- Mandatory training or counseling
- Suspension with or without pay
- Demotion or reassignment
- Termination of employment

The severity of the disciplinary action will depend on the nature, frequency, and severity of the violation, as well as the employee's history.

14. Acknowledgment

All employees are required to read, understand, and acknowledge this Code of Conduct upon hire and annually thereafter. Acknowledgment forms are available on the Acme HR Portal.

15. Policy Compliance and Questions

Employees with questions about this Code of Conduct should contact the HR department at hr@acmecorp.com or extension x4500, or the Ethics Hotline at (555) 246-8100.

This Code of Conduct is subject to change at the discretion of Acme Corp management. Employees will be notified of material changes via email and the Acme HR Portal.